Behind the Mask

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Behind the Mask

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Summary

After their separate investigations and many missions, the Rebellion is about to go on a final mission to try and free all the chipped Etherians while She-Ra finds and destroys the Heart of Etheria. However, Shadow Weaver is not going anywhere as she's not part of either mission, and Castaspella felt the need to stay for another moment to have a final conversation with her.
Their interactions have been unusual since the beginning, but if they hadn't worked together, the Rebellion wouldn't have this chance now. There is both too much and too little that can be said, and the Head Sorceress of Mystacor won't let this opportunity go without trying her luck at making her speak.

After working with her so closely, she felt she could do this; Shadow Weaver wasn't as bad as they thought, but she wouldn't say it aloud...

Notes

Disclaimer:
I'm aware the idea might seem foolish, and this is the rarest rarepair, but I just couldn't help thinking there had happened *something* before Catra returned to the hideout and, taking some details into consideration, I thought "what if earlier she had a conversation she wanted to pretend never happened?". I mean, if you listen to how Shadow Weaver answers Catra, she sounds pretty much drunk, which I found rather curious.
This is what I imagined that conversation could have been, and this fic is dedicated to the one friend who bore with me and fully supported the idea.
Rewatching I realized I'm not mad: there seems to have been some hint at a potential relationship (if not romantic at least friendly enough) between these two, and hopefully you'll notice my references to canon events. Finally, some things like what the heck happened while they were away, investigating alone, were left unsaid, which gives me full freedom to speculate and add to the fic.
Hopefully you'll enjoy it and see what I concluded from those episodes in Season 5.

Edit: Today, Feb 14th 2024, I am retouching (without significant changes) the way this is written. Mostly just syntax

See the end of the work for more notes

The fateful day had arrived. Today they would attempt to destroy the Heart of Etheria and defeat Horde Prime once and for all. She-Ra would take care of the Heart and instructed the others to aid Princess Entrapta in sneaking into Prime's ship. Now, everyone was ready and unhurriedly left the hideout for the mission that would free every chipped Etherian. However, Castaspella lingers, she was waiting for everyone to be out before addressing a sulking Shadow Weaver at the back of the place.

The sorceress noticed her approaching and nonchalantly asked —Why aren't you already gone with the rest to help Entrapta?

—Ah, so you *can* still talk. It seemed for a moment you had gone mute— Castaspella retorted with annoyance before she could think better about it. She took a deep breath and composed herself before saying —Look, it's obvious something is upsetting you, and it so happens we haven't seen Catra since returning from Mystacor. Do you perchance know what could have happened?

Castaspella's tone and expression said more than enough, Shadow Weaver knew she wasn't actually asking if she knew something but rather *what* she had done to her, so there was no point in deflecting.

—Well…

—Ah, forget it…— Castaspella sighed, interrupting her. Her sudden change of decision confused Shadow Weaver, but it then baffled her when she added —I don't know why I asked you, you can hardly be trusted. You'd just make something up before telling me what happened.

—Maybe if you listened…

—Are you *really* going to answer?

—I'm *trying*—. Shadow Weaver's annoyance was clear in her voice yet she remained mostly calm. Only after Castaspella abandoned her suspicious look in favor of an expecting attitude, like inviting her to answer, did the sorceress start speaking again. —During our little excursion to Mystacor, and since, I've been trying to convince Adora to stay away from Catra and telling her she was a distraction, and it's clear Catra overheard. So now that Adora did as I said and took the failsafe, she's probably gone to brood somewhere because Adora chose to follow my plan. It's nothing new, actually— she casually explained while seated on some crates, seemingly unwilling to move at all.

—Really? Just a fuss, you say?

—I'm telling you, it wouldn't exactly be the first time I caused those two to fight.

Shadow Weaver was talking with such carelessness Castaspella simply couldn't believe her. She kept looking at the sorceress in disbelief with her arms crossed in front of her chest.

—As I said, you're so hard to trust— she finally uttered. Shadow Weaver stared at her, even more confused than before. —It's what you do. You adapt to where you are, and with that mask on it's just *so* easy for you to deceive others, isn't it? How would anyone know? And these are the perfect circumstances to make up such an elaborate story. It's totally plausible, I'll give you that.

—Wait, what!?

Indignant, Shadow Weaver finally got up and advanced towards her, and yet Castaspella didn't flinch.

—Will you try to deny it? Everyone knows it, you have no attachments, you're constantly adapting… Ugh, you're like a shape-shifter!

—Don't you *dare* compare me to them! And I am not trying to deceive you!

For a split second, they stared at each other with absolute rage. A moment later, they looked down almost at the same time to find Castaspella's hands were closed in tight fists, and Shadow Weaver had grabbed her by the wrists just as tightly. The sorceress let go of her and she loosened her fists, realizing she was angrier than she thought.

After all the yelling, Castaspella's voice seemed like a murmur.

—All you know, other than deceiving, is power and violence— she began. —You never understood you can't *control* magic, because magic simply *is*. When you attempt to control or own it… well, I don't have to tell you what happened to you, do I?— she reminded her. Right after, a thought interrupted her, changing her expression. —Just… what are you *even* doing here? Why did you stay? By now you must have realized you can't get any more power. I know what you tried to do with Glimmer, and there's nothing else you can do to get power from her, you'll kill her if you try, and none of us will allow it.

—It is *not* that…

She scoffed and insisted —Then what? There's nothing else for you here, or at the resistance, at all. Why linger? What is it that you want to obtain?

Castaspella, despite her incredulity, questioned her calmly; she was genuinely interested in knowing, not simply accusing her. Yet Shadow Weaver hesitated and held her hands together, regretting this whole conversation.

Noticing as much, she thought it was better to leave and let the sorceress go back to her lonely sulking. However, when Castaspella turned around to leave, a hand caught her wrist again, gentler this time, and she stopped. After a moment, Shadow Weaver released her, but she didn't move.

Letting out a sigh, the sorceress admitted —You wouldn't believe me, Cas.

Castaspella gasped, frozen in place.

She couldn't possibly have heard right.

Had she really heard *her* use the nickname she suggested?

Hadn't she said she'd "never do something so ridiculous"?

She remembered when they went to investigate, as suggested by Shadow Weaver, any possible way to awaken Etherea's magic; they had come to a deal: if she tried to take the magic for herself, Castaspella would stop her at any cost. Such an agreement darkened the mood almost completely and she was left feeling uncomfortable. However, realizing she had a fake idea of who Shadow Weaver was and even of who Light Spinner used to be, because of the stories she had heard, she convinced herself this was a good chance to actually get to know her, regardless of what she had been told about the *terrible* Light Spinner.

But her attempts at being friendly were mostly futile at first. She seemed to only get on her nerves, and the sorceress kept pronouncing her name with such anger it made her feel like a child again. Only after she proved helpful in their research did Shadow Weaver show some more politeness; she didn't know Castaspella either so she might have won her respect upon demonstrating her skills. Only with that lighter mood had she dared suggest they also treated each other in a more friendly manner. She told Shadow Weaver she could, for instance, call her "Cas", and she would find a nickname for her. At first, the sorceress seemed to go with it, even put up with her ramblings for a while, but when she heard her saying she'd maybe call her "Spin", Shadow Weaver utterly refused to allow her to do so, or to accept calling her "Cas" either, considering it was a ridiculous thing to do and that she was being too naïve.

She told her she'd try to be "friendlier" and that was it.

So now Castaspella couldn't understand why she's using the nickname. She wouldn't even say "please" when they sneaked into Mystacor! What *was* she trying to do!?

She looked back at Shadow Weaver, wanting to ask her, but the sorceress had her back towards her. Only then did Castaspella notice she was holding her mask in her left hand.

—What…

—I am not here for power— she began. —You were right, however. This is but a means to an end, once again. I don't pretend to save anyone, I'm not here to help the resistance. I have my selfish reasons— she admitted. Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and turned around, this time to look at Castaspella without her mask, showing her real face. Her sorrow, her pain, but also her resignation, were all clear in her scarred visage. —I deceived Micah, used him to get power, and when everything went wrong, I resorted to violence considering it the only choice left for me. That is true, just like you said— she recalled. Her voice was as severe as usual, calm and collected, but being able to see her expression, Castaspella knew she was making an effort to admit all of this, even to herself. —And yet, this time I'm not here for power, if I had to resort to violence it would only be as a last resort for I have little power left in me. Once again, I am *not* trying to deceive you. I may be in no position to ask you to trust me, and yet, you should know you can; after all, you now know me as much as Micah did back then and as much as Adora does now. I just can't deceive you because you can see through my lies.

Castaspella shook her head while retorting —Me? See through your lies? Wasn't I just "Micah's weak sister"? Oh right, I think "naïve" is what you called me.

—Oh, please. You have serious confidence issues, don't you?— Shadow Weaver mocked her lightheartedly.

Castaspella first got angry, but now that she could see her expression, she knew the sorceress was making fun of her but not trying to insult her. She felt her face turn red when she realized it was just what she had asked for: Shadow Weaver being friendly.

—Fine, fine. Just get to the point already.

—The point is… Micah has already decided he won't forgive me; he even grunted at me when I protected him and that princess from one of Prime's robots—. She let out a sigh, focusing on staying on the subject. —And I understand his decision, I don't deserve his forgiveness. You, however… you're willing to listen to me, and you deserve to know I always regretted ruining my relationship with him, that I genuinely cared for him as my own son. I felt proud of being his tutor, and it was *never* my intention to put him in harm's way— she expressed. It wasn't the first time they discussed the events related to the Spell of Obtainment, but now that Castaspella could see behind the mask, she knew the true pain Shadow Weaver felt reminiscing about it. —I was blinded by my pride and thirst for power, there's no denying it, but I also had full trust in Micah. It would have worked had he not broken the connection, I've said it before. Although, I suppose I should have known he'd be afraid. It was reckless, or rather, irresponsible of me to have him help me regardless. *That* is where I failed—. She stopped for a moment, closed her eyes, and took a deep breath. Then, she pointed at her face and said —I already admitted that spell was a mistake, and here you can see the price I paid, yet that's merely the surface. My grief for all I lost only hardened me. After that, I never wanted to forge a relationship like the one I had with him ever again. I knew I'd only repeat the same mistakes—. She looked down and let out a bitter laugh. —Ah… but isn't it always power? I raised a lot of children in the Fright Zone, always kept them at arm's length, scared and obedient. And then Hordak brought Adora. I felt it instantly, the power within her was so strong even then; since I first had her in my arms, I loved that girl and wished she was my own daughter, and yet none of that could stop me from repeating the story.

Castaspella silently listened to her, focused on how her expression showed true pain and a hint of madness when she thought about the power, only to quickly disappear under a grimace of shame. Having noticed the confused feelings Shadow Weaver had, how it seemed like part of her was almost out of her control when it came to gaining power, she let herself feel sympathy.

Sympathy. She couldn't actually allow herself to be sympathetic to Shadow Weaver, could she? What if this was all an elaborate lie, all tailored to make her think she was seeing a side of her no one had seen? Castaspella suddenly felt stupid for her feelings and had to disguise them, she couldn't let her know she was falling for it.

—Someone is being unusually honest today— she tried to joke.

But the look she got from Shadow Weaver almost broke her heart as she showed such genuine resignation.

Her voice was suddenly weaker but she managed to say —That is what happens when you look behind the mask.

Now Castaspella regretted doubting her; she was being honest, *for once*.

She looked away, hugged herself, and softly asked —Why did you suddenly realize all of this? Why now?

—Well, my failure at not forging bonds with those I tutored repeated once again with Glimmer— she began. Castaspella instantly looked back at her, she knew what she meant. —I accidentally built and automatically ruined a relationship with her that, just like it happened with Micah and Adora, was almost impossible for me to avoid. The look on her face when I explained how sorcery works and she quickly picked up on how to properly cast a spell… She had the same expression he once had. Her reactions and her passionate investment in perfecting her casting brought back every memory of Micah I had tried to forget—. She let out a deep sigh. —And so, this time I clearly saw all the mistakes I had made with him, I realized I had done it all over again, and understood I'm just unable to keep myself from hurting those I care for. I genuinely loved them, but I was simply unwilling to stop using them, or show that I really cared, to the point they all currently hate me, and with all due right. Yet it's no use understanding or admitting that now, everyone I've ever helped in a way, I've also hurt in another, all I could have done wrong, I've done it— she explained, her expression fixed on some point to her left, unable to look her in the eye.

Castaspella dared take a step towards her and said —You think even Adora hates you? Was that why Catra jumped like that? Because of what you've done to her?

Shadow Weaver nodded as she replied —They especially hate me. You saw her reaction at my mere touch. I've traumatized her enough that she couldn't even stand me when her life depended on it—. Once again, she seemed resigned when she said —I can't blame them, and there is nothing to salvage from our relationship. I'm telling you, the people I loved the most, Micah, Adora, Catra, are also the people I've hurt the most; it's the only thing I'm good at—. Castaspella was speechless and the sudden look of resolve in Shadow Weaver's face kept her attentive. —Now I can only do all in my power to make sure they survive, despite all my mistakes, all the suffering I myself brought upon them. I can't be forgiven, I can't expect to find peace for myself, yet I can make sure my influence won't make their lives even worse. I still fail to do so, but I have to keep trying and make sure the three of them will survive this, save Etheria, and outlive me.

Shadow Weaver finally looked at Castaspella and noticed her eyes watering, her expression between shocked and moved, and felt it was time to put her mask back on, so she turned around and fixed it over her face.

A moment later, the sorceress felt an embrace from behind and heard —I'm sorry…

Castaspella was *hugging* her; now it was *her* turn to be frozen in place.

With a neutral tone, unsure how to react, she asked —Why? You've done nothing wrong.

—I did *nothing*, that's exactly the problem— she began, without letting go. —I just believed all the stories I was told about you; misjudged you from the beginning. You willingly came to us and yet I never gave you a chance. I was so sure all I had been told was true, I was so bitter about how you risked Micah, that I wouldn't allow myself to believe you really cared about him— she continued, holding back her tears, yet her voice betrayed her feelings. —I wanted so much to believe it was all manipulation… I wouldn't let myself find out if what you said was true, and… I even thought just earlier you were deceiving me, but since you were freed by Glimmer you had never even *tried* to do so. When Micah got chipped and I went to the groove where you had been hiding, you came directly to me, even… even tried to comfort me, right after I had complained about you *not* being chipped. I was so mean to you yet you patiently insisted; you *knew* I was worried about him and I ignored how comprehensively you behaved.

Then, she finally let go of her to try and calm down, taking a deep breath with her eyes closed. Once she opened them, Shadow Weaver was looking back at her through her mask once again.

—I suppose I felt no need to deceive you— she admitted.

—Still…— Castaspella insisted, trying to recover her voice. —We keep treating you like a monster. *I* do. But fully blaming you for our distrust isn't fair at all.

—But then you trusted me, enough to even support me in front of everyone when we returned here with the plan to get the Failsafe from Mystacor.

—And now, like a hypocrite, I said you can hardly be trusted. Come to think about it, that's not because of whether you lie or not, but rather because little to none of us are willing to trust you. That's *on us*. And for that, I apologize.

—I see…— she replied, her voice barely audible. —Thank you.

Castaspella took a deep breath, feeling clearly relieved, and teased her —I'm actually glad we could talk, Spin.

—Don't push your luck…

—Fine— she complied, suppressing a giggle. —And, I'm sure Catra will come back, she can't be *that* angry, right?

—Of course she can— Shadow Weaver assured her with sarcasm.

—But, I wanted to ask… Why were you trying to separate them? Why were you telling Adora…

—Listen— she interrupted her. —I can't understand how you all always use love to gain strength. I have always believed love makes you weak— she began, making Castaspella roll her eyes at how she pronounced "love". —However, I recognize Adora only unleashed her full potential when she came with you, so I tried to make her use her love to her advantage. I told her if she loves Catra then she should focus on protecting her. And even so, she's still

struggling to transform— she continued. —I am truly at a loss. How *is* it that you all just summon some hidden strength out of nowhere simply because of "love"!?— she exclaimed with such disbelief it almost made Castaspella laugh. But before she could say anything, Shadow Weaver added —I can't understand it. I just know *that* is the only reason we, actually you, stand a chance against Horde Prime.

Castaspella smiled gently and answered —You don't have to understand it, just accept it. Accept that your power is so great you could do so much more if you only weren't so afraid. You know, afraid of embracing the love you feel for them—. She giggled and added defiantly —You could do something good with that power for once, no? For a change.

—You mean like you do?— she replied, intending it as a joke. But Castaspella's expression fell; the sorceress noticed a hint of hesitation she instantly tried to disguise. Concern quickly gripped her but she wouldn't allow herself to let Castaspella know, so she kept the lighthearted teasing tone to provoke her —If you plan to waste time here any longer, you better tell me why.

She looked away, feeling especially exposed, and closed her hands tightly to the point her knuckles were white.

—I am not… I won't be of any help. I can't face Prime's forces while he has control of Micah— she admitted. —I don't have enough power, strength, or skill for this.

—Nonsense. What you lack is confidence— Shadow Weaver stated. —Aren't you the Head Sorceress of Mystacor? You should be overconfident, not the opposite.

—Well, that means little when I'm always considered to be "too young" and lack experience — she quickly retorted. —The other tutors are ancient, some even were already teachers when *you* taught there.

—Stop that now. Who cares if they are ancient or if I am too? You need to give yourself more credit for your achievements, especially if, being younger, you already outrank them— Shadow Weaver stated, dismissing Castaspella's concerns with obvious contempt for her old colleagues. —Usually, only I was fast enough to counter Micah's spells, mostly because I could guess his moves; he learned from me, after all. But, back in Mystacor, *you* kept up with him for so long; I *know* you are strong enough. Young? Of course, but no less powerful than me—. She insisted until it was clear she wasn't exaggerating but rather pointing out a fact. Approaching her, she concluded —Focus on the Rebellion, on those you now have to protect. They can use your help and *will* need it because none of them can do what you can. And you don't need to be stronger than Micah, you are strong enough to stand your ground against him. Why could you do it then and not now? You only need to keep him and the other chipped princesses at bay for enough time. You can do it.

—Hopefully Glimmer will be back to support us before I mess up— she sighed, as if she hadn't heard Shadow Weaver at all.

—Aren't you listening to me!?—. The sorceress was indignant yet again, but this time, she took Castaspella's hands between hers to make sure she'd pay attention. —You *are* strong enough. You only need to trust *yourself*! And if you do get Glimmer's help, then trust her too.

Trust that her powers will be enough to counter Micah's black magic, and even overpower it. Because neither you nor I can possibly imagine the lengths of her sorcery and runestone magic combined— she stated, looking directly into Castaspella's eyes, which were fully opened in astonishment. —Don't doubt yourself if you have the chance to assist Glimmer; you can be of great help to her, as long as you have enough confidence in your *own* magic and its capacity to support her casting, despite seeming so little, there will be no spell you can't do.

—You… really trust her— she let out.

—As much as I believed in her father before her. She lacks experience but she's also a quick learner, she just needs *support*, Cas. One I know you are more qualified than me to give— Shadow Weaver replied.

Castaspella let out a faint smile and looked up to her as she said —Thank you.

She then looked back at the exit and Shadow Weaver knew she was about to leave, but she hadn't let go of her hands yet. Unexpectedly, Castaspella looked back, pulled her hands, and quickly kissed her mask. Without another word, she turned around and walked away.

As soon as she was out of her shock, Shadow Weaver exclaimed —Take care of Micah!

From the exit, Castaspella looked back at her, nodded with a smile, and then used a spell to catch up with the others.

Left alone once again, Shadow Weaver could hardly believe anything that had happened, it even felt like a fever dream.

She began rummaging around, mumbling to herself —There must be something to drink around here.

Minutes later, she was once again seated on some crates, an almost empty cup on her right hand, and her mask on her left hand. She felt now more light-headed, the memory of that particular conversation with Castaspella became more bearable and she was overall more relaxed. She didn't want to think about the dangers the others were facing, she just told herself it would all be over soon; they were about to destroy the Heart and soon the chipped would be free.

Horde Prime was doomed.

Suddenly, she felt Catra nearing and her first instinct was to put her mask back on. Soon, she could hear the girl's heavy panting moments before she rushed into the hideout.

—Adora! A-Adora!— she shouted desperately, scared even.

—She's not here— Shadow Weaver carelessly declared from her seat as she looked at the chalice in her hand.

—What do you mean she's not here?— Catra questioned her angrily.

—She's gone to the Heart of Etheria to free the magic and become the hero she was born to be— she answered, her tone a bit *too* relaxed, as she got up and walked towards Catra…

End Notes

Well, what do you think? Does it make sense? At least a tiny bit?
I've come to love the idea of how their dynamic would have been, had they ever got a chance to actually have a relationship of any kind, so I may end up giving my hands and mind free reign on some future fics. I'd like to explore what it would have been like (if SW hadn't died), and I saw this one fanart where she was shown as a spirit to be looking out for catradora's child, so I may one day dare to post a more creative fic using that same concept... we shall see...

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!